

BPL DeskBook

Starved of resources

Weighing 4.25 Kgs, the BPL DeskBook was the bulkiest, measuring about 50 mm thick. The dull silver-grey finish and grey plastic used for the keyboard and touchpad give it a bland look. It has well spaced keys and a large palm-rest. The touchpad is sensitive, but its buttons are tacky. It's configured with a desktop Intel Pentium 4 1.5 GHz, 128 MB of RAM, a 40 GB hard drive, a 15-inch LCD screen and a DVD-ROM. The processor is underpowered, and 128 MB of RAM isn't enough to run Windows XP. There is no standby battery, so you have to calculate your usage.



The only exciting feature is the flash memory card reader. BPL has also provided a carry handle for the DeskBook; fold back the carry handle to use it as a peg that inclines the DeskBook while typing. Interestingly, it has the best ventilation system, and stayed at 32 degrees Celsius even after 4 hours of use.

Its performance was nowhere near the ACi laptops. In the Business Winstone, the measly 128 MB took its toll and the system returned a mere 14 units. Video-encoding took over 2 and half minutes. However, the standard IDE hard drive scored impressively. The onboard 845 display adapter did a poor job on graphics.

The BPL DeskBook is priced at an affordable Rs 61,900. Though this is quite okay for its configuration, we recommend it only if you need an affordable desktop replacement that you do not wish to use on the move and can sacrifice on performance.

Price: Rs 61,900
+ Great build-quality
- No batteries

BPL Deskbook		B-
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Usability	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Fujitsu LBC 2220

Fashion victim

The Fujitsu LBC 2220 marries great looks with perfect ergonomics and a decent performance to give birth to a great product.

It comes with an Intel Pentium 4 M 2.2 GHz, 256 MB of RAM, a 14.1-inch crisp TFT LCD and a 30 GB hard drive. The underlying Radeon chipset provides an integrated graphics adapter for some decent gaming. Four USB ports, a serial and parallel port each, are provided. Apart from the Ethernet and modem connector, it also features wireless connectivity. A memory card reader is also included.

Lighter shades of silver on its outer surface and a darker silver grey on the inside, give the laptop a distinct style statement. The off-white keyboard gels perfectly with the theme, as does

3D Gaming on Laptops

Gaming on laptops has evolved in leaps and bounds today, from playing simple games such as *Solitaire* and *FreeCell*, to graphically intensive and complex *Quake III* and *Unreal 2*. This has become possible due to the availability of powerful processors such as the Pentium 4-M, and the introduction of better graphics chipsets such as the Geforce Go series from nVidia, and the Radeon Mobility range from ATi. But for an avid gamer, playing games on a notebook will never offer the same depth and immersion as playing on a desktop computer. This is partly due to the presence of the thin liquid crystal-based displays for the notebooks. Although LCDs are the obvious choice as display units due to their minimal weight and sleek design, the flatness of their screens limits the viewing angle. Also, while playing 3D games on a LCD, the player's view often appears to be boxed and limited, giving the impression of a 2D game, rather than a full-blown 3D experience. Though, this can be corrected by wearing special 3D glasses while viewing 3D applications, but these glasses are usually very expensive and hard to obtain. A more practical and simpler method has been discovered to convert the flat screen of a LCD into a 3D display, using plain transparent cellophane—sheets of plastic used for packaging. This cellophane technique is based on the principle of how humans perceive three-dimensional objects in their field of vision, and the fact that the light from a LCD is polarized light.

Human vision is stereoscopic in nature, i.e. besides length and width; we can also gauge depth and height, and therefore discern and correctly identify 3D surfaces and objects. While looking at any object, both the right and left eye send separate images to the brain, which then merges the two, and then gauges the actual depth and distance of the object from the differences in the images. But our visual system is not sensitive enough to gauge the difference between ordinary light and polarized light. Ordinary light consists of a scattering of light waves, which vibrate in different planes from each other; whereas in polarized light, the light waves vibrate coherently in a single plane. The main advantage of polarised light is that it can be blocked and manipulated very easily just by altering its direction of polarization. Cellophane has this distinct ability to rotate the direction of polarization of any polarized light passing through it.

The light from the LCD in laptops is linearly polarized due to the presence of a polarizer sheet covering the top surface of the liquid crystal screen. Now take a cellophane sheet, and cover half of the laptop screen with it. This will create an effect wherein your left and right eyes will perceive two slightly different images due to the polarization occurring at one half of the screen. The 3D effect is finally obtained, when a crossed polarized sheet i.e. a sheet which has its polarizers oriented at a difference of 90 degrees to the cellophane on the laptop, is placed a little distance away from the screen, in front of the observer. And so, with a little bit of ordinary cellophane, you can enjoy an unrestricted and complete 3D experience, while playing your favourite 3D games.